PIA3121 Theories of International Relations — Week 6 Summary: Constructivism

1. Lecture Framing and Course Position (Slides 1–3)

Keywords: Week 6, midterm quiz, Weeks 1–6, Viotti & Kauppi, Ukraine opening case

- Week 6 (6 Oct 2026) closes the first block of the course: Tools of Analysis → Realism → Liberalism → Neorealism and Neoliberalism → Economic Structuralism and Globalization → Constructivism (Slide 2).
- **Midterm quiz: 13 Oct** — covers Weeks 1–6, so constructivism is the last examinable theory before it (Slide 2).
- Reading: Viotti & Kauppi, "Constructivist Understandings".
- **Opening image:** map of the Russian invasion of Ukraine, 24 February 2022 – present — Russian-occupied territory in the east and south, plus Crimea (Slide 3).
    - → Test case: material power alone, or how the two states **represent** each other?

2. Core Claims of Constructivism (Slides 4–11)

Keywords: identity, rational actor critique, neo-neo rationality, socialization, interests learned, structuration

2.1 States Are Not All Alike (Slides 4–5, 8)

Keywords: identity, values, perceptions, aspirations, worldview, foreign policy

- Constructivism's opening move: you **cannot assume all states are alike as "rational actors"** (Slide 4).
- States vary significantly in their identity: their values, perceptions, aspirations, and ways of looking at the world — and identity in turn **shapes foreign policy** (Slide 4).
- → Contrast with neorealism, which treats states as "like units" differing only in capabilities (Week 4). Constructivism says the units themselves differ in **who they think they are**.

2.2 Which Kind of "Rational"? Neorealist vs Neoliberal States (Slides 5–8)

Keywords: relative gains, absolute gains, utility-maximizer, cooperation, neo-neo debate

- Even if states are rational, **whose rationality** — neorealist or neoliberal? (Slides 5, 8)
- **Neorealist state** (Slide 6): every "normal" state is rational, **suspicious, self-regarding, amoral utility-maximizer** determined to increase its power **relative** to other states — even at the risk of inviting costly conflicts.
- **Neoliberal state** (Slide 7): every "normal" state is rational **but predisposed to cooperate** in international society and to smooth over conflicts.

    - Goal: maximize absolute utility — utility compared with what was accrued in the past, or what might be gained now or in future from a different course of action (Slide 7).

- Comparison (memorise):

    - Neorealist = **relative gains**, suspicion, conflict-prone.
    - Neoliberal = **absolute gains**, cooperation-prone.

- → Constructivist point: "rationality" is not a neutral fact; the two neo-schools *impute* different rationalities. Which one a state displays depends on its identity and context.

2.3 Interests Are Not Self-Evident: Socialization (Slide 9)

Keywords: interests learned, identity acquisition, socialization, introjecting norms, international/world society, domestic culture

- State interests aren't self-evident — states aren't "born" knowing what to go after (Slide 9).
- They **learn** what to go after by acquiring identities through socialization — introjecting the norms of international or world society and of their own domestic cultures (Slide 9).
- → Rationalists take interests as **given** (exogenous); constructivists explain **where interests come from** (endogenous).

2.4 Structuration: The Endless Cycle (Slides 10–11)

Keywords: structuration, agent–structure co-constitution, Giddens, duality of structure, mutual construction

- Through **day-to-day policies and actions**, states help construct international **and** world societies; these in turn interact with domestic cultures and construct them, in an endless, ongoing cycle (Slide 10).
- Structuration: the ongoing, mutual construction of agents and structures — agents' actions produce and reproduce structures, which in turn shape the agents (structuration theory, associated with Giddens).
- Diagrams (Slide 11):

    - **Left:** actions ↔ resources ↔ norms & values ↔ meaning — all feeding back on each other.
    - **Right — "The Structurated Duality":** agents' **knowledgeability** and **structural principles** constitute each other.

- One-liner: *states make the system; the system makes the states.*

3. Wendt's Cultures of Anarchy: Anarchy as an Empty Vessel (Slides 12–17)

Keywords: Wendt 1999, anarchy, empty vessel, Hobbesian/Lockean/Kantian, culture, shared ideas

3.1 Anarchy Has No Intrinsic Logic (Slides 12–14)

Keywords: anarchy, levels of analysis, empty vessel, logics of anarchy

- Slide 12 recalls the levels-of-analysis diagram with **"ANARCHY!"** at the system level — the shared starting point of realists and neo-schools: no authority above states.
- Alexander Wendt 1999 (*Social Theory of International Politics*; title slide "Cultures of Anarchy", Slide 13) reinterprets it.
- Key quote (memorise): "Anarchy as such is an empty vessel and has no intrinsic logic; anarchies only acquire logics as a function of the structure of what we put inside them" (Slide 14).
- → Against neorealism: anarchy does **not** automatically produce self-help and power balancing. What it produces depends on what states fill it with.
- Standard shorthand (from Wendt 1992): *"anarchy is what states make of it."*

3.2 Three Kinds of Anarchic Structure (Slide 15)

Keywords: Hobbesian, Lockean, Kantian, global or regional level

- An international anarchy, at the **global or regional** level, can have one of three structures (Slide 15):
  - Hobbesian culture (after Hobbes's war of all against all)
  - Lockean culture (after Locke's rights-respecting state of nature)
  - Kantian culture (after Kant's perpetual peace)
- → Same anarchy, three different "logics" — the decisive variable is culture, not the number of great powers.

3.3 Culture as Shared Ideas (Slides 16–17)

Keywords: shared ideas, social structure, culture, material vs ideational, meaning of interests

- Each structure is fundamentally constituted by shared ideas among member states; these shared ideas "make up the subset of social structure known as 'culture'" (Slide 16).
- Wendt accepts that social structures have **material** aspects too, but culture — as shared ideas — is "the most fundamental fact about the structure of an international system, giving meaning and power and content to interests" (Slide 16).
- Slide 17 marks this with 🤯: the claim inverts realism.

- Realism: material power is fundamental; ideas are secondary.
- Wendt: ideas are fundamental; they tell actors **what material power means**.

4. Roles: Enemy, Rival, Friend (Slides 18–22)

Keywords: subject position, role, enemy, rival, friend, role-identity, structural property

4.1 The Dominant Role in Each Culture (Slides 18–21)

Keywords: subject position, dominant role, three roles

- Each structure centres on a **dominant role** played by member states (Slide 18) (memorise):
  - **Hobbesian → "enemy"** (Slide 19)
  - **Lockean → "rival"** (Slide 20)
  - **Kantian → "friend"** (Slide 21)
- Subject position: the dominant role that a culture of anarchy assigns to its member states (Slide 19).

4.2 Roles Belong to Structures, Not to States (Slide 22)

Keywords: roles vs role-identities, objective positions, collectively constituted, persistence

- Roles are attributes of the structures, not of the agents or units — "the objective, collectively constituted positions that give meaning to" subjective self-understandings (Slide 22).
- Distinguish:
  - **Role-identities** — held by individual states; they "come and go as individuals [states] take on or discard beliefs."
  - **Roles** — positions within the structure; they "persist as long as someone fills them."
- → A single state can change its beliefs, but the enemy/rival/friend position remains until the shared culture changes.

5. The Three Cultures in Detail (Slides 23–28)

Keywords: central norms, securitization, sovereignty as institution, security community, non-violence, mutual aid

5.1 Hobbesian Culture: Enemies (Slides 23–24)

Keywords: enemy, securitization, no recognition of right to exist, unlimited violence

- Question: what are the **central norms** of each culture? (Slide 23)
- In a Hobbesian culture, enemies are constituted by **representations of the Other** — i.e. through securitization practices (Slide 24).

    - Securitization: presenting an issue or actor as an existential threat, which justifies extraordinary measures (standard Copenhagen School usage).

- Enemy: "an actor who (1) does not recognize the right of the Self to exist as an autonomous being, and therefore (2) will not willingly limit its violence toward the Self" (Slide 24).
- "An enemy does not recognize the right of the Self to exist as a free subject **at all**."
- → Logic: war of elimination; no limit on violence; survival is the stake.

5.2 Lockean Culture: Rivals (Slides 25–27)

Keywords: rival, sovereign autonomy as right, limited violence, sovereignty as shared institution, post-WWII

- States **freely agree** to recognize and accept each other's **sovereign autonomy as a right**, and refrain from trying to conquer or dominate one another (Slide 25).
- Violence or coercion may still occur, but rivals **do not try to destroy** the other or eradicate its subjectivity/selfhood (Slide 25).
- Rival: an actor that may compete with and occasionally use force against the Self, but recognizes its right to exist and so limits its violence.
- When all states in an interstate society recognize each other's right to autonomous actorhood, "we can speak of **sovereignty** not only as a property of individual states, but as an **institution shared by many states**" (Slide 26).
- Wendt's empirical claim (memorise): **most of the world, most of the time, has been Lockean since the end of WWII** (Slide 27).
- → Lockean = competition with rules; war happens, but conquest and elimination of states become rare.

5.3 Kantian Culture: Friends (Slide 28)

Keywords: friend, security community, rule of non-violence, rule of mutual aid, Western alliance

- As of the late 1990s, Wendt saw a Kantian culture rooted among the **US, Canada, most of Europe, Australia, New Zealand, Japan, South Korea** and others (Slide 28).
- It forms a security community: members see each other **not even as rivals** on the most important questions, but as **friends**.
- Friendship: "a role structure in which states expect each other to observe two simple rules: (1) disputes will be settled without war or the threat of war (the rule of non-violence); and (2) they will fight as a team if the security of any one of them is threatened by a third party (the rule of mutual aid)" (Slide 28).
- *Example:* NATO's collective defence clause matches the mutual-aid rule; war between, say, Canada and the US is unthinkable — the non-violence rule.

6. From Lockean to Kantian: Four Master Variables (Slides 29–39)

Keywords: collective identity, interdependence, common fate, homogeneity, self-restraint, efficient vs permissive cause

6.1 The Causal Logic (Slides 29–30)

Keywords: efficient cause, enabling/permissive cause, collective identity formation, fear of engulfment

- Four **master variables** can cause transition from a Lockean to a Kantian culture (Slide 29) (memorise): **interdependence, common fate, homogeneity, self-restraint**.
- Two types of cause:
    - Efficient (active) causes: factors that actively drive collective identity formation — interdependence, common fate, homogeneity.
    - Enabling (permissive) cause: a condition that allows the efficient causes to work — self-restraint.
- All four may be present; the more present, the more likely collective identity forms (Slide 30).
- **Minimum condition:** one efficient cause + self-restraint (Slide 30).
- Self-restraint enables states to solve "the fundamental problem of collective identity formation: **overcoming the fear of being engulfed by the Other**" (Slide 30).
- One-liner: *any one push (interdependence, common fate, homogeneity) + the brake on fear (self-restraint) = path to Kant.*

6.2 Interdependence and Altercasting (Slides 31–32)

Keywords: objective vs subjective interdependence, social dilemma, defect, cooperate, altercasting, internalization

- Interdependence must be **objective** to cause collective identity; "the problem is changing objective into subjective interdependence" (Slide 31).
- **Defection reproduces egoism:** choosing to "defect" in a social dilemma also reproduces the egoistic identities that create the dilemma (Slide 32).
- **Cooperation builds collective identity:** by cooperating, Ego implicitly takes on a collective identity, acting "as if" he cares for Alter — even for initially selfish reasons (Slide 32).
- Altercasting: by cooperating, Ego signals to Alter "I expect you to do the same in return," casting Alter into a cooperative role (Slide 32).
- If Alter reciprocates → Ego's tentative identity is reinforced → further cooperation → over time, **internalization of collective identity on both sides** (Slide 32).
- → Identity is **practised into being**.
- *Example:* post-war Franco-German economic integration (coal and steel) as cooperation that gradually reshaped former enemies into partners.

6.3 Common Fate (Slides 33–35)

Keywords: common fate, objective condition, "same boat", norm entrepreneurs, epistemic communities, fear of exploitation

- Common fate: actors face a common fate when their individual survival, fitness, or welfare depends on what happens to the group as a whole (Slide 33).
- Must be an **objective** condition to count as a cause; subjective awareness of being "in the same boat" is already **constitutive** of collective identity, not a cause of it (Slide 33).
- Perceptions of common fate may depend on **"entrepreneurs"** and/or epistemic communities who lead in reframing how actors understand themselves; such leadership is not always present (Slide 34).
- **Not sufficient** alone: as with interdependence, actors may fear **exploitation** by others in the collective, so believing partners will show **self-restraint** matters (Slide 35).
- *Example:* a shared external threat or climate change objectively ties states' welfare together; scientists (an epistemic community) can frame it as a shared fate.

6.4 Homogeneity (Slides 36–37)

Keywords: objective homogeneity, subjective categorization, recategorization, group differentiation, Othering

- Collective identity presupposes members **categorize themselves as alike** along the group's defining dimensions (Slide 36).
- So the causal link runs from **objective homogeneity** to **subjective categorization**: increases in objective homogeneity cause actors to **recategorize others as like themselves** (Slide 36).
- Counter-force (Slide 37): actors may **invent or problematize new sources of group differentiation** to shore up the boundary between the group Self and the Other.
    - This need for difference does **not** have to mean aggression or disrespect ("Othering"), nor block collective identity on other issues.
    - But it **weakens the link** between homogenization and prosocial behaviour.

6.5 Self-Restraint (Slides 38–39)

Keywords: permissive cause, fear of engulfment, trust, egoism, Realism's source

- Interdependence, common fate and homogeneity raise incentives for **prosocial behaviour**, which erodes the egoistic boundaries of the Self and expands them to include the Other (Slide 38).
- This only proceeds if actors overcome their fear of being engulfed, physically or psychically, by those with whom they would identify (Slide 38).
- That fear is "the source of egoism and 'Realism'" (Slide 39).
- To get past it, actors must **trust** that their needs will be respected and their individuality not wholly submerged by or sacrificed to the group (Slide 39).

- "Creating this trust is **the fundamental problem** of collective identity formation" — especially hard in anarchy, "where being engulfed can be fatal" (Slide 39).
- → Realism, on this reading, is not a law of nature but the product of unresolved fear.

7. Constructivism and Military Security: Jepperson, Wendt & Katzenstein (Slides 40–51)

Keywords: JWK, Culture of National Security, security environment, international cultural environment (ICE), identity

7.1 Security Environments Are Cultural (Slides 40–41)

Keywords: material vs cultural, institutional environment, decisive

- Source: Jepperson, Wendt & Katzenstein 1996, in *The Culture of National Security: Norms and Identity in World Politics* (Katzenstein 1996, ed.) (Slide 40).
- Claim: states' security environments are **not just material** (e.g. balance of military power) but also — importantly, even **decisively — cultural or institutional** (Slide 41).

7.2 Three Layers of the International Cultural Environment (Slides 42–46)

Keywords: ICE, security regimes, world political culture, amity and enmity, regions

- International Cultural Environment (ICE) has three layers (Slides 42–46) (memorise):
  - (1) **Formal institutions or security regimes** (Slide 43).
  - (2) **A world political culture** (Slide 44).
  - (3) **Enduring patterns of amity and enmity**, particularly within regions (Slide 45).

7.3 Example: Canada vs Cuba (Slides 46–47)

Keywords: amity, enmity, threat perception, identity over capability

- "Which country is — to the U.S. — the nice country?" (Slide 47): maps of **Canada** (Mounties) and **Cuba** (Fidel Castro).
- Large neighbouring Canada is a friend; small Cuba was treated as a threat.
- → **Identity, not material power, shapes threat perception** — layer 3 in action.

7.4 JWK's Key Novel Argument (Slides 48–49)

Keywords: incentives vs identities, constitutive effect

- ICE elements don't just affect the **incentives** facing states to behave in certain ways (Slide 48).
- The ICE also affects the **basic character of states: their identities** (Slide 49).
- → Rationalists: environment changes **behaviour** (regulative effect). JWK: environment changes **who states are** (constitutive effect).

7.5 Breakthrough: Beyond the Neo-Neo Debate (Slides 50–51)

Keywords: neo-neo debate, neo-neo synthesis, intrinsic actor properties, rejection

- JWK: "We **reject** the prevailing assumption, shared by Neorealists and Neoliberals alike, that the defining actor properties are **intrinsic to states**, that they are all power-seeking and (material) interest-maximizing rational actors" (Slide 50).
- Marked 🤯 (Slide 51): the challenge targets **both** mainstream schools at once.
- One-liner: *constructivism attacks what the neo-neo synthesis agrees on, not what it disputes.*

8. The ICE's Three Effects on State Identities (Slides 52–56)

Keywords: survival, modal character of statehood, variation in statehood, norms and roles

- Three effects (memorise) (Slides 52–56):
    - (1) Elements of the ICE can affect some states' very **prospects for survival** (Slide 53).
    - (2) Changing ICE elements may change "the modal character of statehood" — the typical form a state takes in a given era over time (Slide 55).
    - (3) ICE elements may cause **variation in the character of statehood within one international society**: states may be similar in structure and function but **compelled by norms to play different roles** (Slide 56).
- World political map of today's sovereign states (Slide 54):
    - → Under a Lockean sovereignty norm, even small, weak states survive; contrast the empire maps of 1815 and 1900 (Section 9).
- *Example (effect 2):* the shift from empires to nation-states after decolonization.

9. Case: Six Primary Norms of Imperialism (Slides 57–67)

Keywords: imperialism, civilized/uncivilized, legitimate conquest, balance of power, mercantilism, non-interference

9.1 Imperial Norms 1–3 (Slides 57–61)

Keywords: standard of civilization, rule over foreigners, accumulating a domain

- Map "The World in 1900" with flags of the era: most of Africa and Asia under European empires (Slide 58).
- Six norms of the imperial ICE (memorise):
    - (1) **The world is divided into civilized and uncivilized realms** (Slide 59).
    - (2) **Ruling over foreigners was acceptable** (Slide 60).
    - (3) **Accumulating a domain was a legitimate state pursuit** (Slide 61).

9.2 US Imperialism (Slide 62)

Keywords: Pacific expansion, backyard, 1898, Western Hemisphere interventions

- "US imperialism in the Pacific and in 'its own backyard'" (Slide 62):
    - **Pacific:** Alaska (purchased 1867), Midway 1867, Hawaii 1898, Philippines 1898, Guam 1898, Johnston Island 1898, Wake Island 1899, American Samoa 1899.
    - **Caribbean:** Puerto Rico 1898, Cuba naval bases 1898.
    - **Involvement in:** Mexico, Guatemala, Honduras, Nicaragua, Panama, Santo Domingo, Venezuela; Boxer Rebellion (China) 1900.
- → Even a state with an anti-colonial founding identity followed the imperial norms of its era.

9.3 Imperial Norms 4–6 (Slides 63–67)

Keywords: balance of power, mercantilism, colonial non-interference

- (4) **Power should be balanced** (Slide 63).
- (5) **Mercantilist economic policies were legitimate** (Slide 65).
- (6) **States should not interfere in other states' colonial administration** (Slide 66).

- World map of 1815: Russian, Qing, Ottoman and British empires; Spanish/Portuguese America (Slide 64).
- "The World in 1900" map repeated (Slide 67).
- → Conquest was once **legitimate** because the ICE said so; today it is illegitimate under sovereignty norms (contrast Slide 54 with Slides 58, 64, 67).
- → Illustrates ICE effect 2: the **modal character of statehood** shifted from empire to sovereign nation-state.
- *Example:* the Ukraine war (Slide 3) is condemned as a violation of the post-WWII norm against conquest — a norm that did not exist in 1900.

10. Challenges to Constructivism (Slides 68–72)

Keywords: realist critique, rationalist critique, problem of change, "good norms" problem

- Four critiques (memorise) (Slides 68–72):
- **1. Realist critique** (Slide 69): does constructivism pay enough attention to **hard military and economic power**? Realists: norms are nice, but **secondary to material capabilities and survival instincts**.
- **2. Rationalist critique** (Slide 70): identity and culture are **too vague and hard to measure**; neoliberal and neorealist critics say constructivism **lacks the predictive power** of rational-choice models.

- **3. Problem of change** (Slide 71): strong at explaining how norms create **stability** and constrain actors; weaker at explaining **where norms come from** or **why they sometimes collapse suddenly**.
- **4. "Good norms" problem** (Slide 72): it explains the spread of both **good** norms (human rights) and **bad** norms (imperialism, slavery) — a tool for understanding **process**, not for assessing the **moral content** of ideas.

11. One-Page Revision Spine

Keywords: last-minute recap, Wendt, JWK, ICE, imperial norms, critiques

1. **Core claim:** states are not identical rational actors; they differ in **identity** (values, perceptions, aspirations, worldview), which shapes foreign policy (Slide 4).
2. **Which rationality?** Neorealist = suspicious, relative-gains power-maximizer; neoliberal = cooperative, absolute-gains maximizer (Slides 5–7).
3. **Interests are learned** via **socialization** — introjecting international/world-society and domestic norms (Slide 9).
4. **Structuration:** states and international/world society and domestic cultures construct each other in an endless cycle (Slides 10–11).
5. **Wendt 1999:** anarchy is "an empty vessel"; culture (shared ideas) is the most fundamental fact of system structure (Slides 12–17).
6. **Three cultures → roles:** Hobbesian = enemy; Lockean = rival; Kantian = friend. Roles belong to the structure and persist as long as someone fills them (Slides 18–22).
7. **Hobbesian:** enemy built by securitization; denies the Self's right to exist; unlimited violence (Slides 23–24).
8. **Lockean:** sovereignty as a right and shared institution; limited violence; global norm since WWII (Slides 25–27).
9. **Kantian:** security community of the US and allies; friendship = **non-violence + mutual aid** (Slide 28).
10. **Lockean → Kantian:** interdependence, common fate, homogeneity (efficient) + self-restraint (permissive); minimum = one efficient cause + self-restraint (Slides 29–30).
11. **Mechanisms:** cooperation and **altercasting** internalize collective identity; common fate needs entrepreneurs/epistemic communities; homogeneity → recategorization; self-restraint builds **trust** against fear of engulfment, the source of "Realism" (Slides 31–39).
12. **Jepperson, Wendt & Katzenstein 1996:** security environments are cultural, even decisively; ICE layers = security regimes, world political culture, regional amity/enmity (*Canada vs Cuba*) (Slides 40–47).
13. **Key novel argument:** the ICE shapes **identities**, not just incentives; rejects the neo-neo assumption that actor properties are intrinsic (Slides 48–51).
14. **ICE's three effects:** survival prospects; modal character of statehood; variation in roles (Slides 52–56).
15. **Six imperial norms:** civilized/uncivilized; ruling foreigners; accumulating domain; balance of power; mercantilism; colonial non-interference — plus US expansion; maps 1815/1900 vs today (Slides 57–67).

16. **Four critiques:** realist (material power); rationalist (vague, unpredictive); problem of change; "good norms" problem (process, not morality) (Slides 68–72).